

Everything For Everyone

A small rag-tag bunch of programmers with a will to Change The World become technology's rock stars, and even if you don't fully understand it, it's hard not to have a soft spot for the philosophy of Open Source

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In the 1980s, if you owned an Apple II series computer, you could buy yourself a copy of *Nibble* magazine and leaf through its pages to find the BASIC source code for a small utility or game—complete with an explanation of what each block of code does. If you were just a user, you could just type out that code into your command line and proceed to enjoy your program. If you had programming knowledge and didn't like the way a feature worked, you were free to change it—no strings attached.



(Mis)Understanding Freedom

There's been a lot of controversy around the terms "free" and "open source". Richard Stallman's definition of free software is quite clear—freely available software that gives the user freedom to create, modify and redistribute. Unfortunately, this clashes with the other definition of free software—as in free of cost. The loose definition of open source software—software whose source code is freely available—addresses this somewhat, but as mentioned, it's a *loose* definition based on the definition of free software. In his words: "Open source is a development methodology; free software is a social movement. For the free software movement, free software is an ethical imperative, because only free software respects the users' freedom. By contrast, the philosophy of open source considers issues in terms of how to make software "better"—in a practical sense only."

So why is Open Source our wonder and not Free Software? Open source culture has reached a point where it's a healthy compromise between Stallman's freedom and the need for software developers to make money. Moreover, the definition of free software can't be extended beyond—free and open source beer, for example, would lead to a rather large number of inebriated college students. With open movies and music, there are grades to freedom—some are available as Public Domain ("do what you want"), others can let you enjoy and modify, but not distribute that modified version.

None of this can be called bad or "oppressive"—it's just part of our changing world. Free is our Xanadu, Open is the reality we live in.

For most of us, open source software's biggest selling point is that it's free of cost. In the early days of the movement, however, the objective was much more serious.

Why

In the 70s, all software was free and open source—primarily because if you weren't in a university lab, you had no need to be using software. If you were in a lab, you probably got the program's source code from a fellow academic who wanted to share it with you. You could then tweak the code to work with your computer (architectures varied, and you didn't live in the standard x86 world you do now), and fix any bugs you might find in the code. You could also add to the program's capabilities and hand the new source code back to your colleague, simply because this is how academics and researchers work—in collaboration with each other.

But then, someone made seventy duplicates of a pre-release copy of Altair BASIC at a hobbyists meeting, urging those seventy to "go forth and share". This invited the ire of the developer, who had planned to sell the program—he'd anticipated that computers would soon move beyond the lab and into the real world, and selling software would be a good way to make money off that move. In an open letter to the group, this developer—a pimply-faced lad named Gates—condemned this activity, and called the hobbyists thieves. It's an interesting read, and you can find it here: http://www.digibarn.com/collections/newsletters/homebrew/V2_01/homebrew_V2_01_p2.jpg.

There were responses to this, of course—including one which gently advised him not to call his target audience "thieves", but the damage had been done. Others got the idea—AT&T began charging for Unix,

and the era of "proprietary" software began. Naturally, there had to be a rebellion, and by the early 80s, that rebellion was called the Free Software Foundation.

But was it really so unthinkable to pay for software?

Tools > Preferences

We've come to take the customisability of our software—even the paid tools—for granted. You can tweak a bunch of settings to get the program working the way you want to (within limits, of course). In the beginning, however, you had to take what the programmer gave you. At a time when proprietary software was mostly compilers and interpreters, there was no difference between users and developers—the people who used these programs were often fully qualified to modify it and fix its bugs. Imagine their frustration to know that they could fix a program, but can't. Clearly the alternative was to fight the fight for free software—software that can be shared and modified without restriction.

Today, however, less than 10 per cent of the people who use open source software actually contribute to the development of a project—for the rest, reasons vary from "It's free!" to "I don't want to be oppressed by proprietary software". But if the free software movement is such a great cause, why are its evangelists the underdogs?

Perhaps it's something to do with the roots of open source software, and the fact that traditionally, open source software has been more developer-friendly than user friendly. That, thankfully, has changed a lot.

Linux And You

Clearly the most important open source project in recent times has been the Linux operating system. It